Command I do not think enviable,' he wrote to his cousin shortly after meeting Macnaghten.

> It is one of expense, responsibility, and anxiety . . . There are not many officers to give me much advice, most of them like myself having only lately come into this country. The Political Agents, generally young officers, are frequently proposing schemes for the execution of which they are not responsible. A proposition was lately submitted to Govt. for an advance on Herat, a distance of 600 miles from Kabul through country abounding with difficulties, and where supplies requiring 4000 Camels have to be carried . . .
>
> [Macnaghten] is cold and reserved, but I believe very clever . . . Shah Shuja I saw two days ago, a stout, careworn-looking man. He received me in a wretched garden, his house appeared bad and uncomfortable, as indeed are most here – no one except Sir W. M[acnaghten] possesses much more than a mud hut. The King leaves this on the 10th when I am expected to go too, which is rather annoying as I intended marching by myself and his *ragamuffin* retinue will be a great nuisance on the road.[11]

A week later Elphinstone finally arrived in Kabul, which depressed him even more than Jalalabad. 'The City is extensive, very dirty & crowded,' he observed. 'The cantonment [meanwhile] is not very defensible without a number of men, as people can come in from without at many points. This, in the event of troops being required elsewhere, would be very inconvenient, & I am a good deal puzzled as to what is now the best thing to be done.'

Elphinstone was not the only one puzzled by what should be done in Afghanistan. Even Macnaghten, the most delusionally optimistic of the British, now recognised that despite the surrender of Dost Mohammad all was not well.

To the south-east, the Punjab was now declining into hostile anarchy: within two years three Sikh rulers had followed each other as leaders of the Khalsa. As a result, a leaderless military regime of evasive and uncertain sympathies now lay between the army of occupation in Afghanistan and its commissariat base in Ferozepur. 'The Punjab remains so unsettled that all the spare troops are obliged to be kept on that frontier,' wrote Emily in April 1841. 'Runjeet's death has been so like the death of Alexander, and of half the great conquerors of ancient history that we used to read about. His army was a very fine thing, and his kingdom a good kingdom while he was there to keep an eye on them, but the instant he died it all fell into confusion, and his soldiers have now murdered their French and English